

PHOTO BY CHANDRADEEP KUMAR



NOT SO COOL A home appliances showroom in Noida

harsh summer this year—as forecast by the IMD—to result in more sales. This is important as home appliance firms, including AC makers, have suffered heavily in the last three summers due to Covid-19. In 2021, AC sales fell 10–12 per cent. While the market rebounded to 9 million units a year in 2022 from 8 million in 2019, companies remain cautious as rising prices may deter purchasers. ACs and mass-market refrigerators were also affected by poor rural market demand and intermittent rains over April and May. Nandi says demand for high-end frost-free refrigerators is consistent, but mass-segment direct cool models—that make up 70 per cent of the Indian market by volume—are suffering. AC makers still struggle with low demand. Due to unseasonal rains, Whirlpool's net profit dropped 25 per cent, YoY, in the March quarter. Based on new mid-premium launches and “accelerated cost reduction programmes,” Narasimhan Eswar, MD of Whirlpool Of India, expects profitability to rise.

“We hope the situation improves gradually and we are not increasing prices as of now,” says B. Thiagarajan, MD of Blue Star. But, not everyone is on the same page. While players like Havells, Samsung, and LG are not ready to reveal their pricing plans for the next six months, sources say prices of home appliances will rise by 6–12 per cent before the festive season begins. Looks like another cruel summer for consumers. **BT**

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spending quotient—also determine the rank on the list.

“Bengaluru's high streets have a high concentration of food and beverage destinations across sub-formats, with several breweries and drinking holes co-existing with other retailer categories,” says Divya Agarwal, VP–Research at Knight Frank India. “Due to its demographic spread... the proportion of non-modern retail remains limited to one-third of Bengaluru's total high street stock, spread across seven prominent high streets. With a two-thirds proportion in terms of the real estate footprint, Bengaluru is the top city amongst modern retail areas across India.”

Contrary to popular belief, the top high streets do not command the highest rents. For instance, Bengaluru's four markets charge retailers much lower rent (see chart) than New Delhi's Khan Market and Gurugram's DLF Galleria—which are not even in the Top 10. New Delhi's Khan Market (₹1,000–1,500/sq. ft/

SHOP TILL YOU DROP Top 10 high streets in India

RANK	HIGH STREET	CITY	RENTS PER SQ. FT./MONTH)
1	MG Road	Bengaluru	₹100-125
2	Somajiguda	Hyderabad	₹150-175
3	Linking Road	Mumbai	₹350-1000
4	South Extension–Part I & II	Delhi	₹250-450
5	Park Street and Camac Street	Kolkata	₹300-450
6	Anna Nagar	Chennai	₹150-175
7	Commercial Street	Bengaluru	₹220-250
8	Sector 18 Market	Noida	₹150-250
9	Brigade Road	Bengaluru	₹180-250
10	Church Street	Bengaluru	₹200-250

Source: Knight Frank Research

month), Gurugram's DLF Galleria (₹800–1,200), and Mumbai's Linking Road (₹350–1,000) are the top three high streets in terms of rent.

“As cities in India modernise, we see many high streets reviving as facilities like access, parking, store

visibility, etc. have improved. Our estimates say that the average per sq. m revenues of high streets will be significantly higher than those of malls in FY23–24,” adds Baijal. **BT**

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